PENGZHEN LI

Knoxville, TN
+1 (865) 266–5815 | pli26@vols.utk.edu | Homepage: pengzhenli.github.io/industry/
linkedin.com/in/pengzhen-li-435702258 | github.com/PENGZHENLI | Google Scholar

SUMMARY

Economics Ph.D. candidate (expected May 2027) combining causal inference, structural estimation, and large-scale optimization. Built a stochastic supply-chain optimization model spanning 1,374 U.S. counties, estimated a strategic game among Brazil's 5,570 mayors, and ran a triple-difference design on the universe of Chinese customs records (2000–2014) for my job market paper. Four peer-reviewed publications (one with 1,000+ citations) and six working papers. Python, R, Stata, SQL, GAMS. Authorized to work in the U.S. without sponsorship.

EDUCATION

University of Tennessee, Knoxville Jan 2021 – May 2027 (expected)
Ph.D. in Economics — fields: international trade, applied econometrics, environmental and resource economics

Shandong University, Jinan Sep 2016 – Jun 2018
M.A. in Finance — thesis published in *Technological Forecasting and Social Change* (1,000+ citations)

Tongji University, Shanghai Sep 2011 – Jun 2015
B.A. in Economics

SKILLS

Programming / software: Python (pandas, numpy, statsmodels, scikit-learn), R, Stata, SQL, GAMS, MATLAB, Git, LaTeX; ArcGIS.
Methods: causal inference (difference-in-differences, event study, IV, RDD, synthetic control, fixed effects); structural estimation; panel and time-series econometrics (GMM, threshold models, VAR/VECM); forecasting; mixed-integer and stochastic optimization; game theory; machine learning; text-as-data.
Credentials / languages: CFA Level II; English (fluent), Mandarin (native).

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Doctoral Researcher, Department of Economics, University of Tennessee 2023 – present

- *Selling Down-Market: Market Access and the Quality of Chinese Exports* (job market paper): compared the same firm's U.S. and non-U.S. sales of a product before and after the 2001 U.S. grant of permanent normal trade relations to China, using the universe of Chinese customs records (2000–2014); export quality fell about 5% more in highly exposed products, on impact and without reversal, with no counterpart in the EU. Built a model in which better access lets firms sell down-market, to buyers who value quality less.
- *Trade Restrictiveness Indices with Discriminatory Tariffs* (with J. Lake): extended the welfare-based tariff index to preferential (non-MFN) tariffs with large-country effects; separated where-to-buy from what-to-buy distortions and computed the index for 123 importers (2000–2020) from BACI/WITS data; in 2018 preferences cut the median simple average tariff by 16% but the index by only 5%. Presented at the Midwest Trade Meetings, 2025.
- *The Impact of Mayoral Endorsements on Presidential Election Outcomes: Insights from Brazil* (with M. Van Essen, L. Lima; 2024 Holly Award): modeled mayors' endorsements of presidential candidates

as a discrete-choice game of incomplete information; established identification and implemented a maximum-likelihood estimator with equilibrium constraints in GAMS, which recovers the structural parameters to within 1% in Monte Carlo experiments.

Graduate Research Assistant, University of Tennessee Jan 2021 – Aug 2023

USDA NIFA and FAA ASCENT funded projects on sustainable-aviation-fuel supply chains.

- Built mixed-integer optimization models (GAMS) to design cost- and profit-optimal forest-residue sustainable-aviation-fuel supply chains across the Southeast U.S.; published in *Biomass and Bioenergy* (2026) and *Transportation Research Record* (2024).
- Ran facility-siting and regional impact analysis with IMPLAN and efficiency analysis with DEA; delivered scenario and sensitivity results (EMP, supervised ML, @RISK) to an interdisciplinary engineering–economics team and federal sponsors.
- Engineered reproducible ArcGIS/R/Python pipelines for high-resolution spatial data.

Earlier applied projects 2016 – 2020

- Panel-threshold evidence on green innovation and CO_2 (*TFSC* 2019, 1,000+ citations); synthetic-control estimate of the Wenchuan earthquake's long-run output effect; GMM analysis of trade-war and COVID farm-aid payments (MFP/CFAP) and U.S. agricultural lending; threshold-VAR/VECM/GARCH commodity-price models; equity-premium prediction from *NYT*/*WSJ* text.

PUBLICATIONS

- *Biomass and Bioenergy* (2026), first author — spatial optimization of aviation-fuel supply chains
- *Transportation Research Record* (2024), first author — aviation-fuel conversion technologies
- *J. Agricultural and Applied Economics Assoc.* (2023) — beef price spreads and processing capacity
- *Technological Forecasting and Social Change* (2019) — green innovation and CO_2 (1,000+ citations)

TEACHING

Instructor: ECON 351 Monetary Economics (Spring 2025, 2026); ECON 322 The Global Economy: Trade and Development (Summer 2025); ECON 313 Intermediate Macroeconomics (Summer 2026).
Teaching assistant: Ph.D. Microeconomic Theory and Mathematical Methods (ECON 511, 512, 581); Agribusiness Operations Research (AREC 525).

HONORS

Charles B. Garrison Award for Excellence in Teaching (best teaching), University of Tennessee 2026
Summer Graduate Assistantship, University of Tennessee 2025
J. Fred and Wilma Holly Award (best second-year paper), University of Tennessee 2024
J. Fred and Wilma Holly Fellowship, University of Tennessee 2023 – present